

Tone & Author's Attitude — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: **60 min**

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — NOTES, STRUCTURES & TECHNIQUE

DEFINITIONS

Tone = the writer's attitude towards their subject, shown through word choice. **Mood** = the feeling created in the reader. They often match, but not always.

TECHNIQUE — 3 STEPS

1. Find words with strong **connotation** (the feeling attached to a word, not its literal meaning)
2. Decide: is the connotation positive, negative, or neutral?
3. Name the precise tone word — never just say "the writer feels bad/good," name it exactly (e.g. bitter, wistful, mocking)

tone word bank — COPY THIS

Positive: admiring, affectionate, nostalgic, hopeful, celebratory. Negative: bitter, scornful, mocking, resentful, anxious, contemptuous. Neutral/complex: matter-of-fact, wistful, ironic, resigned, ambivalent.

SENTENCE FRAME TO COPY

"The word '____' has [positive/negative] connotations, creating a ____ tone, which suggests the writer feels ____ about ____."

2 · PRACTICE — 4 PASSAGES, 20 QUESTIONS

EXTRACT A

The new shopping centre, all glass and forced cheerfulness, had swallowed the little bakery whole, along with everything else that had made the high street worth visiting.

1. Identify one word or phrase with negative connotations.

2. What tone does this word choice create?

3. What does "swallowed" suggest about the writer's view of the shopping centre?

4. Is the writer's attitude to the old high street positive or negative? Give evidence.

5. Write a sentence using the sentence frame to explain "forced cheerfulness."

EXTRACT B

Well, of course the meeting ran two hours over — meetings about "efficiency" always do.

6. What tone is created here: sincere or ironic?

7. Which two words in quotation marks hint that the writer doesn't believe them?

8. What effect does putting "efficiency" in quotation marks have?

9. Name this tone precisely using the word bank.

10. Rewrite the sentence in a sincere, non-ironic tone.

EXTRACT C

She still kept his handwriting on the shopping list stuck to the fridge, years after he'd stopped needing to write one.

11. What tone is created by this detail?

12. Which word bank term best fits: nostalgic, mocking, or anxious?

13. Explain how the detail of "years after" affects the tone.

14. Is the mood created in the reader sad, angry, or tender?

15. Write your own tone-word sentence about this extract.

EXTRACT D

Naturally, the council found £2 million for a new roundabout the week after cutting the library's opening hours in half.

16. What does "naturally" suggest here — genuine agreement or sarcasm?

17. Which tone word fits best: admiring or scornful?

18. What is being contrasted in this sentence?

19. What is the writer's attitude to the council's spending choices?

20. Write a sentence using the sentence frame to explain "naturally."

Apply this every time: Never describe tone as just "positive" or "negative" — always use a precise tone word from the bank, and always quote the exact phrase that creates it.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

1. "swallowed whole"
2. negative/critical
3. destructive, consuming
4. Positive to old high street, negative to new centre
5. Model using frame
6. Ironic

7. "efficiency"
8. Signals writer doesn't mean it sincerely
9. Ironic
10. Model sincere rewrite
11. Nostalgic
12. nostalgic

- 13. Shows lasting grief/love, not fleeting
- 14. Tender/sad
- 15. Model using frame
- 16. Sarcasm

- 17. scornful
- 18. Roundabout funding vs library cuts
- 19. Critical/disapproving
- 20. Model using frame